

SMALL TEAMS, BIG IDEAS

Through its pursuit of innovative initiatives, Amazon India has created a happier and more fulfilling workplace

By Binu Paul

TWO PIZZAS. THAT'S all it takes to feed a team at Amazon. But it's not just about the food, it's about the philosophy that guides its success. Amazon's 'Two Pizza Team' approach is one of the key drivers of its innovation, collaboration and nimbleness. By keeping teams small, the retail giant fosters a start-up-like culture, where experimentation and creativity thrive.

70 | "When you look at our history, it's all been about builders innovating on behalf of customers, doing things that had never been done before. That's allowed us to invent everything from Kindle to Alexa to AWS. Because we have so much innovation and experimentation going on at any one time, it feels like we're a network of a thousand start-ups," says Deepti Varma, VP of People Experience and Technology at Amazon Stores, India & Emerging Markets.

This 'start-up-like culture' is built around empowering employees to continuously improve their skills and innovate on behalf of their customers. The 'Single Threaded Leaders' concept is an example of it, which offers leaders the autonomy to assess product problems, determine teams and divide responsibilities. This approach, Varma says, has led to sharper focus, creativity, innovation and accountability across operations. Also,

Amazon's 'Talent flywheel' enables employees to continuously improve their skills, break free from self-imposed limitations and make high-judgement decisions at scale.

The commitment to empower its employees extends to its leadership development programmes such as Amazon Future Builders Program that immerses premier B-school students in a variety of upskilling sessions and social activities, while programmes like Pinnacle and Catapult offer leadership development opportunities, specifically for women. Programmes such as Amazon Research Days provides a forum for machine learning experts to connect and share ideas, while Amazon WoW supports women in engineering colleges and helps them build long-term careers in technology.

Amazon understands that a happy employee is a productive employee and therefore, fostering employee happiness should be more than just a lofty ideal; it's a smart business strategy that cultivates a culture of productivity, innovation and success. The company offers flexible work arrangements to accommodate personal needs. Its 'Ramp Back' programme allows new parents to return to work gradually after parental leave. 'Svasthya', a wellness initiative, offers multiple choices to support physical, mental/emotional and financial well-being. It also offers support to



6 AMAZON INDIA TOP ATTRIBUTES

- WELL-BEING INITIATIVES
- ENGAGEMENT AND CONNECT
- PEOPLE GROWTH INITIATIVES

◀ **DELIVERING HAPPINESS** Deepti Varma, VP of People Experience and Technology, Amazon Stores, India & Emerging Markets